

Course 2: Project Initiation: Starting a Successful Project

Module 1: Fundamentals of Project Initiation

- **Initiation Phase Overview:**

- Initiating the project
- Identifying project scope, goals, and deliverables
- Measure the success of a project
- Identifying stakeholders

- **Project Goals:**

- The goal is what you've been asked to do and what you're trying to achieve.

- **Project Deliverables:**

- Products and services that you will create for your customer, client, or project sponsor.

- **Resources:**

- Budget
- People
- Materials

- **Project Charter:**

- A document that clearly defines the project and its goals, and outlines what is needed to accomplish them.

- **Cost Benefit Analysis:**

- The process of adding up the expected value of a project—the benefits—and comparing them to the dollar costs.
- **Calculating costs and benefits:** The process is also called calculating return on investment, or ROI. The easiest way is to compare the upfront and ongoing costs to its benefits over time.
- **ROI Formula:** $(G - C) \div C = ROI$ (where G = Gains, C = Costs)

- **Determining Benefits & Costs:**

- **Benefits (Questions to ask):**

- What value will this project create?
- How much money could this project save our organization?
- How much money will it bring in from existing customers?
- How much time will it save?
- How will it improve the customer experience?

- **Costs (Questions to ask):**

- How much time will people have to spend on this project?
- What are the one-time costs?
- Are there any ongoing costs?
- What about long-term costs?

- **Intangible Benefits:**

- These are gains that are not quantifiable, such as:

- **Customer satisfaction:** Will the project increase customer retention, causing them to spend more on the company's products or services?
 - **Employee satisfaction:** Is the project likely to improve employee morale, reducing turnover?
 - **Employee productivity:** Will the project reduce employee's overtime hours, saving the company money?
 - **Brand perception:** Is the project likely to improve the company's brand perception and recognition, attracting more customers or providing a competitive advantage?

Module 2: Defining Project Goals, Scope, and Success Criteria

- **Project Goals:**

- What you want to accomplish
- Why is this a goal?
- Who is involved?
- Where should the goal be delivered?
- To what degree?

- **SMART Goals:**

- **Specific:** The objective has no ambiguity for the project team to misinterpret.
- **Measurable:** Metrics help the project team determine when the objective is met. (How much? How many? How will I know when it's accomplished?)
- **Attainable:** The project team agrees the objective is realistic.
- **Relevant:** The goal fits the organization's strategic plan and supports the project charter.
- **Time-bound:** The project team documents a date to achieve the goal.

- **OKRs (Objectives and Key Results):**

- Combine a goal and a metric to determine a measurable outcome.
- **Objectives:** Defines what needs to be achieved and describes a desired outcome.
- **Key Results:** The measurable outcomes that objectively define when the objective has been met.
- **Levels of OKRs:**
 - **Company/Organization:** Shared across an organization so that everyone can align and focus their efforts.
 - **Department/Team:** Department-level objectives.
 - **Project:** Help define measurable project goals. Project-level OKRs need to align with and support both company and department-level OKRs.

- **Additional Project Questions:**

- Where did this project come from?
- Why is it needed?
- What is the project expected to achieve?
- What does the project sponsor have in mind?
- Who approves the final results?

- **Defining Scope - Key Areas to Clarify:**

- **Stakeholders:** How did the decision come about? Who originated the request? Who approves the scope?
- **Goals:** What is the reason for the project? What isn't working currently? What is the end goal?
- **Deliverables:** What exactly needs to be updated or delivered?
- **Resources:** What materials, equipment, and people will be needed? Will we need to hire contractors or get permits?
- **Budget:** What is the budget? Is it fixed or flexible?

- **Schedule:** How much time do we have? When does it need to be completed?
- **Flexibility:** How much flexibility is there? What is the highest priority (deadline, budget, or quality)?
- **Scope:**
 - **In-scope:** Tasks that are included in the project plan and contribute to the project's goal.
 - **Out-of-scope:** Tasks that are not included in the project plan and don't contribute to the project's goal.
- **Scope Creep:**
 - Changes, growth, and uncontrolled factors that affect a project's scope at any point after the project begins.
 - **Sources of Scope Creep:**
 - **External:** Customer requests, environment shifts, changes in technology.
 - **Internal:** Product improvements, processes changes.
 - **Solutions / Managing Scope Creep:**
 - Make project plans visible and put agreements/plans in writing.
 - **Define project requirements:** Communicate with stakeholders to find out exactly what they want and document those requirements during the initiation phase.
 - **Set a clear project schedule:** Outline all requirements and tasks necessary to achieve them.
 - **Determine what is out of scope:** Come to a clear agreement about potential impacts and document it.
 - **Provide alternatives:** Suggest alternative solutions to customers/stakeholders and consider additional risks (perform cost-benefit analysis if necessary).
 - **Set up a change control process:** Determine the process for how each change will be defined, reviewed, and approved (or rejected).
 - **Learn how to say no:** Explain how additional tasks will interfere with the budget, timeline, and/or resources.
 - **Collect costs for out-of-scope work:** Document all costs incurred, including indirect impacts.

Triple Constraint

- **Success Criteria:**
 - Tells you whether or not the project was successful.
 - Specific details of project goals, deliverables, requirements, and expectations.
 - The standards by which the project will be judged once it's been delivered to stakeholders.
 - **Determining Project Success:** Identify the measurable aspects of your project and get clarity from stakeholders on expectations.
 - **Adoption:** How the customer uses and adopts a product or service without any issues.
 - **Engagement:** How often or meaningful customer interaction and participation is over time.

Module 3: Working Effectively with Stakeholders

- **Accessibility:**

- Actively removing any barriers that might prevent persons with disabilities from being able to access technology, information, or experiences, and leveling the playing field so everyone has an equal chance of enjoying life and being successful.

- **When choosing a team, consider:**

- Required roles
- Team size
- Necessary skills
- Availability
- Motivation

- **Project Sponsor:**

- The person who's accountable for the project and who ensures the project delivers the agreed upon business benefits.

- **Stakeholders:**

- **Primary stakeholders:** People who will benefit directly from the project's success.
- **Secondary stakeholders:** People who are indirectly impacted by the project's success.
- **Influence:** Measures how much power a stakeholder has and how much this stakeholder's actions affect the project outcome.
- **Stakeholder Buy-in:** The process of involving these people in decision making to hopefully reach a broader consensus on the organization's future.

- **Steps for Stakeholder Analysis:**

1. Make a list of all the stakeholders the project impacts.
2. Determine the level of interest and influence for each stakeholder.
3. Assess stakeholders' ability to participate and then find ways to involve them.

- **Prioritizing Stakeholders:**

- A grid mapping stakeholders based on their power/influence and interest.

Prioritizing Stakeholders Grid

- **Suggested Questions for Stakeholders:**

- What are your most important priorities/goals?
- How will this initiative/project support you and your most important priorities?
- What role would you like to play within this initiative/project?
- Here's how I plan to keep people informed; does that work for you?
- What can I clarify for you?
- What are your expectations? What would you like for the project to accomplish?
- What would success look like for you?
- Who else do you recommend I reach out to about this initiative?

- What information or insights do you have that might be challenging for me to find?
- Where do you see me getting support for this initiative? Facing resistance?
- What additional thoughts/questions do you have?

- **RACI Chart:**

- A RACI chart helps to define roles and responsibilities for individuals or teams to ensure work gets done efficiently.
- Determining who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, and Informed on your projects allows you to keep control of the stakeholders' roles on your project.
- **Responsible (R):** Those doing the work to complete the task. (Assigned to complete the task or deliverable).
- **Accountable (A):** Those making sure the work gets done. (Has final decision-making authority and accountability for completion; only one per task).
- **Consulted (C):** Those giving feedback, like subject matter experts or decision makers. (Must be consulted before a decision or action is taken).
- **Informed (I):** Those just needing to know the final decisions, or that a task is complete. (Must be informed after a decision or action is taken).

RACI Chart Structure

RACI Chart Example

RACI Chart Example 2

Module 4: Utilizing Resources and Tools for Project Success

- **Resources:**

- Resources include the people who help execute the tasks of a project.

- **Budget:**

- An estimate of the amount of money a project will cost to complete.

- **Tools:**

- Aids that make it easier for a project manager or team to manage resources and organize work.
- Tools can help track detailed information about all kinds of tasks and make it easy to communicate with lots of different people.
- Tools can help you: Track tasks, manage budgets, collaborate with teammates.

- **Types of tools:**

- Scheduling and work management software
- Productivity tools
- Collaboration tools

- **Project management tools help you:**

- Track task deadlines
- Provide visibility to others
- Manage a budget
- Create helpful diagrams
- Manage contracts

- **Examples of Project Management Tools:**

- Asana (and Asana Guide)
- Basecamp
- Trello
- Jira (Jira Software)
- ClickUp
- Monday.com
- Microsoft Project or Project Libre (open source)
- Smartsheet

- **Productivity & collaboration tools:**

- Online shared documents
- Meeting agendas
- Status updates
- Spreadsheets
- RACI charts
- Project plans
- Presentations
- Project overviews

- Email and chat
- *Examples:* G Suite

- **Documentation:**

- Documenting decisions can help you uncover tasks, timelines, or costs.

- **Project Proposal:**

- A form of documentation that persuades a stakeholder to begin a project.
- It kicks off the initiation phase by influencing and persuading the company to move forward with the project.

- **Project Charter:**

- A formal document that clearly defines the project and outlines the necessary details needed to reach its goals.
- The goal is to clearly define the key details of the project.
- Creating a project charter is a best practice for ensuring that everyone agrees on how to move forward before entering the planning phase.
- Project charters help ensure that you and your stakeholders agree on the details of the project.
- Project charters make clear that the benefits of the project outweigh the costs of the project. (Benefits should always outweigh the costs).

- **Project charters will vary but usually include some combination of the following key information:**

- Introduction/project summary
- Goals/objectives
- Business case/benefits and costs
- Project team
- Scope
- Success criteria
- Major requirements or key deliverables
- Budget
- Schedule/timeline or milestones
- Constraints and assumptions
- Risks
- OKRs
- Approvals

Project Charter Template

- **Cost Benefit Analysis:**

- Business value created
- Money saved
- Time invested

- **Using AI for Project Management:**

- Use AI to create a project charter.

◦ **Tips for iteration:**

- Provide more specific guidance to get what you need
- Share examples of what you were expecting
- Use clear phrasing and short sentences
- Explain why you liked or didn't like the output